

The Perennial Revolt Against Reason

The best lack all conviction, while the worst / Are full of passionate intensity.

— W.B. Yeats, *The Second Coming* (1919)

(A note to the reader: this essay is thirteen pages long, and the author asks — with some humility, but also with some urgency — that you read every one of them. A short anthology of voices closes it, but the real ask is the argument itself. We live in a moment that rewards those who think carefully about what is worth defending. If thirteen pages feels like too much right now, ask whoever sent this to you — they may well have a shorter version, in whatever language you need. Share it freely. And if you need help engaging with the ideas, use generative AI — it is, quite possibly, the cheapest and most accessible tool humanity has ever had for making sense of complex knowledge. Use it without guilt.)

Something strange happens when a society decides it is tired of arguing. The fatigue is always understandable — rational debate is slow, inconclusive, and rarely satisfying; it demands patience from people who are frightened and humility from people who are certain. And so, at regular intervals in Western history, a different offer has been made: stop debating, start believing. Stop asking questions, start following. The arguments will be replaced by a story, and the story will be about you — your people, your destiny, your enemies, your greatness. All you have to do is surrender the one thing that makes the offer necessary in the first place: your willingness to think.

We are living through one of those intervals now. The structure of the offer is always the same, and it is very old. Western political thought has been fighting this battle, in one form or another, for exactly as long as civilization itself. But the choice being forced upon us is the same choice that faced every generation before: whether to place our faith in *critical reason*, with all its limitations and frustrations, or to place it in something more exciting and more dangerous.

This essay is an attempt to map that choice. By reason, we mean something specific and modest: the commitment to persuade rather than coerce, to hold our conclusions loosely because truth is hard and we might be wrong, and to engage seriously with those who disagree most — because they may see something we cannot.¹ This is not an arrogant rationalism that pretends the truth is simply there to be found. It is what Karl Popper called the “open society”: a form of shared life built on the recognition that we are all fallible, that no one has a monopoly on truth, and that the only honest way to manage our disagreements is to keep talking, keep arguing, and keep the conversation open. The irrationalist tradition goes further, and darker: it holds that truth is not

¹This definition originates in Bertrand Russell, *The Revolt Against Reason*, The Atlantic, February 1935.

discovered but made, imposed by those with the will and power to make their interests prevail. This is not humility about the limits of knowledge. It is the abolition of the very standard by which knowledge could be judged at all.

The arguments against reason are not stupid. Many of them were made by some of the most penetrating minds in Western intellectual history — Machiavelli, Rousseau, Marx, Carlyle, Nietzsche — and the habits of thought they gave us run deeper than we like to think. For this reason their arguments must be approached seriously and honestly — not dismissed, but not swallowed whole either. They are thinkers who in the process of building clean stories about human “nature” — as if such a thing were ever anyone’s to define — forgot they were describing complex human interactions. They are thinkers who, in the process of simplifying, forgot their own limits.

This text is not a full history of the irrationalist tradition, but a quick sketch — one that hopes to remind the reader that none of us get to opt out. We are answerable to truth, to conscience, and to one another, and that obligation always starts with ourselves.²

I. The Man Who Told the Truth About Power

Niccolò Machiavelli is the great provocateur of Western political thought — the man who said, in the early sixteenth century, what most political theorists before him had been at pains to deny: that power does not operate according to the rules of ethics, and that pretending otherwise is not noble but foolish.

Machiavelli was a Florentine diplomat who had spent his career watching states rise and fall, watching good intentions produce catastrophic results, watching ruthless calculation succeed where moral rectitude failed. When he sat down to write *The Prince* in 1513, he was drawing on that experience with the honesty of a man who has nothing left to lose. The prince who wishes to maintain his state, he wrote, must learn how *not* to be good. He must know when to use the lion’s force and when to use the fox’s cunning.

In separating politics from ethics — in insisting that the arena of power operates by different rules than the arena of moral life — he created the intellectual permission structure for a tradition in which the question *who is right?* is always secondary to *who*

²If the reader considers these concerns out of touch with today's reality, consider Curtis Yarvin's calls for a "CEO king." This movement, often called neo-reactionarianism, brands itself "the Dark Enlightenment"—a deliberate echo of the nineteenth-century anti-Enlightenment revolt that, through German Romanticism, helped breed the Völkisch movement and ultimately the racialism and irredentism of German fascism. If this argument isn't convincing enough, the reader has likely encountered some milder form of anti-egalitarianism: the claim that democratic principles should be curtailed, though rarely with any precision about how. Some would accept a college degree as a qualifying measure for voting—but why not a PhD then? (At which point, presumably, the reader starts to worry the limits have gone too far.)

is stronger? Once that permission is granted, you are on a road that leads somewhere very dark. It leads to the idea that politics is not a conversation but a competition — a zero-sum contest in which the winner takes all and the loser goes home, or goes to prison, or goes to the gas chamber.³ What matters is not what Machiavelli meant but what he made possible: an entire tradition that would reach its terminus in the charnel houses of the twentieth century.

II. The Prophet of the Strong Man

The vacuum that Machiavelli left did not stay empty for long. Into it stepped Thomas Carlyle — firebrand, prophet, and architect of something far more intoxicating than cool political diagnosis: the cult of the hero.

In his 1840 lectures *On Heroes, Hero-Worship, and the Heroic in History*, Carlyle proposed a theory of history simple to the point of derangement: great men make history. Not institutions, not ideas, not the slow accumulation of cultural change. Great men. The democratic herd are passive, confused, and in permanent need of direction. “The history of the world,” Carlyle declared, “is but the biography of great men.” If history is biography, then ordinary human beings are mere extras in someone else’s story. The institutions designed to constrain the hero — parliaments, courts, free presses — are not safeguards of freedom but obstacles to greatness. The hero does not deliberate; he decides. He does not persuade; he commands.

There is a direct line — intellectual, emotional, structural — from Carlyle’s lecture halls to the Nuremberg rallies. The specific content changes. The template does not: distrust of institutions, celebration of the heroic individual will, contempt for the slow democratic process, and the promise that a great man will cut through the mess of ordinary politics and deliver the nation to its destiny. We know how that promise ends. And yet the template persists, because the emotional needs it addresses — the longing for clarity, for leadership, for a story in which one’s own group is heroic — are permanent features of human life. They do not disappear when their most recent political expression is defeated. They wait.

³It is worth noting that this conclusion sits uncomfortably close to certain strands of thought that would not recognize themselves in Machiavelli’s company. The view that truth is not discovered but made — that power does not merely enforce reality but constitutes it — runs through Hegel’s historicism and into Marx, and surfaces again in later traditions that pride themselves on their distance from the political “right”. The irony is pointed: a political “left” that denies the possibility of objective truth and the binding force of ethics independent of power has, without quite meaning to, arrived at the same destination by a different road.

III. The Philosopher with a Dangerous Gift

Friedrich Nietzsche is the most difficult figure in this story, and the most important. He was simultaneously a genuine philosophical genius and the single thinker whose ideas have been most catastrophically misused. What Nietzsche was not: a nationalist, an anti-Semite, or a proto-fascist. His sister Elisabeth systematically distorted his work to serve the very movements he would have found repellent. The Nazis who claimed Nietzsche as a patron saint were reading a forgery.

What Nietzsche was: a philosopher who identified, with devastating clarity, the psychological foundations of the moral systems his contemporaries took for granted. Morality, he argued, is not the product of disinterested reason. It is the product of power — specifically, of the resentment of the weak against the strong. This is his concept of the “will to power”: not the crude desire to dominate, but the deeper drive to impose one’s values and vision on the world.

The danger is what this argument does to rational moral debate. If every appeal to universal reason is itself a disguised power move, then there is no neutral ground on which to conduct an argument about justice. Every humanitarian appeal to equal human worth is merely a strategy of the weak to restrain the strong. This is why Popper placed Nietzsche in the dock as an enemy of the open society — not because of what he believed but because of what his framework enabled. A politics that draws the obvious conclusions from Nietzsche will be a politics of will: of who has the nerve to impose their vision, who has the strength to make it stick, who can manufacture a compelling enough myth to carry the masses along.

IV. The Prophet of History and the Prophet of Nature

Nietzsche is not the only thinker whose intellectual power became, in the wrong hands, a political weapon. Two figures stand behind much of the modern irrationalist tradition in ways rarely acknowledged with sufficient honesty — partly because their legacies have been claimed by the left, which has always trusted itself to know when it is using an idea well and when it is not. It seems, however, this hasn’t always been the case.

The first is Karl Marx. It would be foolish to deny his appeal. Marx wrote at a moment of genuine and staggering human misery — the early industrial revolution had produced conditions of urban poverty, child labour, and physical degradation that were, by any honest standard, a moral scandal. His diagnosis had a narrative power that few political thinkers have matched. It is precisely this narrative power that led many to accept the rest of his conclusions as inevitable — without stopping to ask whether a story that explains everything is really explaining anything at all.

But Marx did not stop at diagnosis. He built a total system — a theory of history so comprehensive that it claimed to explain not just the past but the future, not just economics but culture, law, philosophy, and consciousness itself. And it is precisely here that Marx crosses the line into something more dangerous: a prophet of historical necessity whose system admitted no serious revision. This is what Popper called historicism — the belief that history has a direction, that its laws can be known, and that those who do not accept the “evident laws” are enemies of the people and of progress.⁴ That is not a political theory. That is a faith. The gulags were not a betrayal of Marxist theory. They were, in a terrible way, its institutional expression.

The second figure is Jean-Jacques Rousseau, and his irrationalism is of a different and more seductive kind. Where Marx looked to history, Rousseau looked inward — to nature, to feeling, to the uncorrupted instincts of the human heart. His response to the limits of reason was to elevate feeling above argument, instinct above deliberation. And once that move is made — once we accept that authentic feeling is a more reliable guide than careful reason — we have surrendered the only instrument we have for distinguishing honest partial truths from tribal prejudice. The General Will is not a will that can be argued about or revised through debate. It is felt, or it is not. And a politics built on felt certainty has, historically, very little patience for those who feel differently.

What unites Marx and Rousseau is the same refusal of intellectual humility that runs through the entire irrationalist tradition. Both built systems large enough to contain every objection. Both located their authority in something beyond rational scrutiny — History, in Marx’s case; Nature, in Rousseau’s. And both made it very difficult for their followers to admit they might be wrong — which is, in the end, the one admission on which the open society entirely depends.

V. Those Who Stayed

The irrationalist tradition has never gone unanswered. At every turn, there have been thinkers who looked into the same abyss — who saw, as clearly as Nietzsche or Rousseau, how fragile reason is, how limited, how often self-deceived — and chose, nonetheless, to stay. Not out of naivety. But because they understood that the alternative was worse, and that intellectual honesty demanded they live within the difficulty rather than escape it.

⁴Conspicuously enough, this seems no different to what the “neo-reactionary” movement seems to propose. “Progress” comes in the form of absolute “tech” monarchs who know clear and absolute rules to run a government as a corporation. Nick Land and Curtis Yarvin, important theorists within the “neo-reactionary” movement list within their influences not only Thomas Carlyle and Marx but also leftist postmodern thinkers such as Gilles Deleuze.

David Hume is perhaps the most striking example. He was the most radical skeptic in the Western tradition — more radical, in his quiet way, than any of the irrationalists this essay has discussed. He showed, with calm and devastating precision, that reason cannot prove causality, that our most basic assumptions about how the world works rest not on logic but on habit — and habit, as the irrationalists would later argue, is never far from power. He looked at the foundations of human knowledge and found them, by the standards of strict philosophical proof, unsound. And then he went to dinner. He played backgammon. He laughed. Hume's skepticism was sane precisely because it did not become a weapon. It was a recognition of limits, not a license to abandon the effort.

Kant read Hume and was, by his own account, woken from his dogmatic sleep. His response was not to retreat from reason but to map its limits with surgical precision. He was explicit: reason, left to its own devices, cannot reach absolute truth. But — and this is the move that separates Kant from the irrationalists who drew similar conclusions — the inability to reach certainty is not a permission to stop thinking. It is a greater obligation to think carefully. Because where clear rules run out, where we are left with the irreducible difficulty of how to treat one another, that is precisely where the work becomes most human. Plato understood this too:⁵ unlike mathematics, which has clear rules and unique answers, dialectic — a fancy name for conflicts of interest, where people with opposing values sit down and try to reach something they can all live with — has no formula, no algorithm, no guaranteed result. And yet it is precisely here that the stakes are highest. What remains after the limits are mapped, Kant found, was enough — enough to ground a moral life, enough to insist that human beings are ends in themselves and never merely means, enough to issue the command — quiet, firm, and entirely unromantic — that we think for ourselves, even when a compelling story is on offer that would relieve us of the burden entirely.

The point is not merely philosophical. If “dialectic” sounds abstract, consider what economists have spent the last 50 years working on. Market failures — risk shifting, debt overhang, asymmetric information, market power — are conflicts of interest made concrete: situations where individual incentives might pull in opposite directions, where no invisible hand resolves the tension, and where the only way forward is for people to sit down, argue, and design better rules together. Dry, technical, and enormously important — this is proof that navigating irreducible conflict is not a philosophical pastime but one of the most practical things human beings do.⁶

⁵It is worth noting that Plato himself is far from an innocent figure in the history of political thought — Popper placed him first in the dock in *The Open Society and Its Enemies*, arguing that his philosopher-kings and his contempt for democracy made him one of the earliest architects of totalitarian thinking. The reference here is narrower: whatever the political implications of his wider system, his insistence that genuine inquiry requires the friction of dialogue — that truth, where it can be approached at all, is approached together — remains worth taking seriously.

What Hume and Kant share — and what separates them decisively from the irrationalist tradition — is that they took the difficulty seriously without letting it defeat them. They refused the conclusion that follows, in the irrationalist tradition, almost automatically: that since reason is limited, we might as well trust feeling; that since truth is hard, we might as well trust power; that since certainty is unavailable, we might as well trust the myth. That refusal — quiet, unglamorous, and enormously demanding — is the core of what the rationalist tradition has to offer.

It is into this tradition that Ernst Cassirer was born, and it is this tradition that he watched, with horror and precision, being dismantled.

VI. When Simplification Became a Machine

Ernst Cassirer was a philosopher of culture, a gentle and erudite man who spent his life studying how human beings make meaning through language, myth, and symbolic forms. He was also a German Jew who watched his country incinerate the civilization he had devoted his life to understanding. His final book, *The Myth of the State*, completed just before his death in 1945, is one of the most chilling documents in modern intellectual history — not because of its rhetoric, which is measured and precise, but because of what it saw so clearly.

Cassirer's central insight: the totalitarian movements of the twentieth century had not simply exploited human irrationality. They had manufactured it. The Nazi mythology was not a spontaneous eruption of primitive sentiment. It was a deliberately engineered product, designed by people who understood, with cold clarity, exactly what they were doing. They had studied mass psychology, identified the emotional needs that democratic politics left unsatisfied, and constructed a myth that addressed those needs with terrifying efficiency.

And they did it by exploiting one of the most double-edged gifts of the human mind: the capacity to simplify. Simplification is not stupidity — it is how we make a complex world legible. It is what makes science possible, what allows us to plan, to act. But a mind under pressure does not want a careful approximation of the truth. It wants a clean answer. One enemy. One cause. One savior. The myth fed the mind exactly what it most desperately wants — the relief of certainty, the comfort of a world divided cleanly

⁶The “neo-reactionary” answer — hand the resolution to whoever holds power, inside companies as much as inside states — does not eliminate these conflicts. It simply decides them in advance, in favor of the powerful. The market failure does not disappear. It just becomes someone's loss that nobody in power is obliged to care about. And when power cannot resolve them internally, violence becomes the next tool. Popper was characteristically blunt about this: a politics built on the primacy of power is not a political philosophy. It is the operating logic of criminals.

into heroes and villains. That someone who supplies the clean answer is also, of course, the one who gets to decide what the truth is.

It is precisely this tension — between the mind's need to simplify and the world's refusal to cooperate — that makes the oldest philosophical injunction in the Western tradition also a political one: **know thyself** — know how you simplify, know what you need to believe, know the shortcuts your mind takes when the world becomes too heavy to hold with precision. The unexamined mind is not just a philosophical misfortune. In the wrong political climate, it is a door left open.

The tragedy is not that people were fooled. It is that they were human — and being human, they wanted a world that made sense. The rationalist tradition has always had to offer something harder: a world that mostly doesn't make sense, and the discipline to live in it anyway. The discipline to go to dinner, play backgammon, and laugh — after dealing with the human condition.

VII. The Moral Foundation They Forgot to Mention

Here is something that tends to be left out of secular accounts of the rationalist tradition, perhaps because it is awkward: the humanitarian values that undergird liberal democracy did not spring fully formed from the forehead of the Enlightenment. They have a history. **And that history runs, in significant part, through Christianity.**

Karl Popper, who was not himself a religious man, was clear-eyed about this. In *The Open Society and Its Enemies*, he argued that the moral tradition most hostile to the irrationalist politics of power was the humanitarian tradition, and that its deepest roots were in the Christian idea of the equal worth of every human soul. Greek society was built on hierarchy — between citizens and slaves, between men and women, between Greeks and barbarians. **The claim that every person, regardless of birth, strength, wealth, or intelligence, was equally precious was not common sense. It was a revolution.**

The irrationalist tradition, by contrast, is uniformly elitist. Carlyle's hero worship requires that most people are passive followers. Nietzsche's will to power requires that the strong have the right to impose their vision on the weak. The fascist movements that drew on both were explicit: some lives mattered more than others. The rejection of egalitarianism is not incidental to these traditions — it is structural. It is what makes them work. What makes this genuinely troubling rather than a matter of intellectual curiosity is that both traditions — the irrationalist and the rationalist — run deep in the Western canon, often through the same thinkers and the same texts.⁷

⁷This is not a minor observation. The Yale University Press series *Rethinking the Western Tradition* was built around a disquieting recognition: that these thinkers have left a mark on how we understand ourselves that goes far deeper than most of us realize, and that is

The Christian tradition has long held, however imperfectly and however often betrayed in practice, that all human beings share the same nature and the same origin, and therefore carry an equal dignity. Not equal talent. Not equal strength. Not equal fortune. Equal dignity — prior to any of those things, and not contingent on any of them. The earliest Christians are the most honest proof of what that ethics actually means. They were not powerful. They had no institutions behind them, no armies, no historical momentum. They were, for the better part of three centuries, a persecuted minority — arrested, condemned, fed to lions. What is remarkable is that they believed it without any worldly evidence that they were on the winning side. Their moral conviction did not depend on success. No one predicted that a persecuted minority in a backwater province of the Roman Empire would plant the seed of the most consequential moral revolution in Western history.

This is an argument about the ethics of early Christianity, not a defense of what institutional Christianity became. The Church that burned heretics, that blessed crusades, that provided theological cover for slavery and conquest, had traveled a very long distance from that persecuted community. But this is entirely predictable — because humans are imperfect, and institutions built by humans inherit that imperfection. The gap between the values we profess and the lives we actually live is not a reason to abandon the values. It is the permanent condition of moral life. The moral seed planted in those early centuries — equal dignity, unconditional, not contingent on power or victory — is one of the genuine foundations of everything we are trying to defend.

The irrationalist tradition, however, never stops trying to undo it. Every time a political movement tells you that some people are more authentically your fellow citizens than others, that some lives matter less — it is making the same move that Carlyle made, that Nietzsche made, that the fascists made. It is asking you to abandon the egalitarian commitment, which feels abstract, in favor of the tribal commitment, which feels immediate and real. The irrationalist tradition does not invent these feelings. It exploits them. It takes what is real and human and turns it into a weapon against everyone outside the circle.

Resisting that offer requires understanding that the egalitarian commitment is not abstract. Without it, rational debate loses its point — why argue with people whose interests don't count? Without it, the open society collapses, because the open society is, at its core, an agreement to treat every participant as someone whose voice deserves to be heard.

not always benign. The series includes — among others — Carlyle, Marx, Kant, Rousseau, and Hume.

VIII. Kant's Magnificent Demand

In 1784, Immanuel Kant published a short essay in response to a question posed by a Berlin newspaper: What is Enlightenment? Enlightenment, Kant wrote, is “man’s emergence from his self-incurred immaturity.” The key word is *self-incurred*. Kant is talking about the immaturity we choose — the comforting habit of letting others think for us, of taking refuge in the certainty that someone wiser and stronger knows better than we do. The motto of Enlightenment: *Sapere aude!* Dare to know. Have the courage to use your own understanding.

Every strongman in history has depended, for his power, on a population tired of the burden that comes with being fully human: the responsibility to think, to doubt, to extend consideration to people who are different, difficult, and inconvenient. The strongman offers relief from all of that. It is a very old offer, and it is always attractive. Kant’s imperative — dare to think — is an assault on that passivity at the level of the individual conscience. It says that the alternative — the surrender of judgment — is a form of moral cowardice, and that a society composed of people who have chosen cowardice will, eventually, get exactly the government it deserves.

The courage to think for oneself is a form of commitment — to truth, to one’s own rational nature, to the community of people who are trying to work things out together rather than letting someone else silence the people you’d rather not deal with.

IX. Popper and Russell: The Modest and Radical Idea

Karl Popper and Bertrand Russell are probably the least glamorous thinkers in this essay. Neither offers a grand prophetic vision or an intoxicating prose style. What they offer is something considerably rarer: clarity about what we can and cannot know, and the practical implications of that clarity for how we should organize our political lives.

The core of Popper’s philosophy is fallibilism — the recognition that all our beliefs are conjectures, liable to error, subject to revision. This sounds modest. It is, in fact, radical, because most political movements — including most naively rationalist ones — operate as if they have access to truths that are beyond revision. The communist believes that history has a knowable direction. The nationalist believes that the people have a discoverable essence. Even many liberals believe that the principles of their politics are simply correct, in a way that should be obvious to any reasonable person.

Russell, writing in the 1930s as fascism was rising, saw the same problem from a different angle. What he identified as the common thread running through the irrationalist tradition was not stupidity but a cluster of emotional preferences given philosophical respectability — the preference for instinct over deliberation, for will over argument, for the intoxication of collective emotion over the sobriety of individual

thought. His prescription, what he called the “scientific temper,” was Popper’s fallibilism in a different register: tentativeness, openness to evidence, and a deep suspicion of any belief held with certainty disproportionate to the evidence for it. Both understood that moral passion is more trustworthy, not less, when disciplined by intellectual honesty.

What distinguishes the rational attitude, in Popper’s account, is not the possession of certain truth but the willingness to submit one’s beliefs to criticism. Applied to politics, this means preferring institutions that can be reformed over utopias that must be imposed, preferring incremental changes that can be reversed over revolutionary transformations that cannot.

When the party cannot be wrong, when the leader cannot be questioned, when the CEO-king’s judgment is by definition beyond appeal — the costs of error are borne entirely by what economics calls the “principals”: those whose interests the “agent” was supposed to serve in the first place.⁸ The parallel with political life is not accidental. Economists have a precise name for what happens when those who make decisions are insulated from the consequences of their mistakes: agency problems. In real life, the interest of the agent and the interest of the principal come apart — and with no mechanism to demand accountability, no institutional check to realign them, the divergence compounds quietly until it becomes catastrophic. Unchecked power is not just morally objectionable. It is, in the most technical sense, a market failure waiting to happen.

Russell called this the scientific temper; Popper called it the open society. The names differ but the demand is the same — and it is one that both men understood would never be finally won. The open society is not a destination but a practice, perpetually in need of renewal, one that has to be chosen and defended by every generation that inherits it.

X. The Same War, New Weapons

It would be a comfort to believe that the arguments of this essay belong entirely to the past — that they were settled, definitively, in the ruins of Berlin in 1945 or in the collapse of the Soviet project in 1991. History, as Popper might have predicted, does not cooperate with that hope.

⁸The precise definitions of “principal” and “agent,” and the full implications of what economists call the principal-agent problem, are worth looking up. They are among the most practically useful concepts in modern economics — and once understood, they have a way of appearing everywhere: in corporate governance, in politics, in regulation, in any relationship where one party acts on behalf of another and their interests do not perfectly align.

The structural patterns of the irrationalist tradition are clearly visible in contemporary politics. They appear wherever a leader presents himself not as a servant of institutions but as the institutions' rightful master — wherever "the people" are invoked as a sacred and homogeneous entity whose will overrides the messy diversity of actual citizens' actual interests. They appear wherever expertise is treated not as a resource but as an enemy, wherever judicial independence is denounced as obstruction, wherever a free press is systematically delegitimized. They appear with a chilling familiarity in the "neo-reactionary" fringe, which openly clamors for tech-driven autocrats and "CEO kings." They appear wherever the offer is made: stop arguing, start believing.

The technology has changed. The deliberate pace of careful argument is at a structural disadvantage in an information environment designed to reward emotional intensity over deliberative quality. Social media platforms optimize for engagement, and engagement is reliably produced not by nuance or evidence but by outrage, by tribal signaling, by the dopamine hit of a perfectly targeted insult. The political mythmakers of our time have better tools than the Nazis and the Stalinists did. They also have better lawyers.

But the deepest thing has not changed. What is being attempted is what Cassirer identified as the fundamental project of political irrationalism: not to win the argument but to abolish the conditions under which arguments can be held. To so thoroughly discredit the institutions of rational accountability — universities, judiciaries, electoral commissions, independent journalism⁹ — that the very idea of a shared factual reality becomes implausible.

Popper, who had seen where that erosion leads, put the choice with characteristic bluntness: "We can return to the beasts. But if we wish to remain human, then there is only one way, the way into the open society." The open society is not a gift but a burden — what he called "the strain of civilization": the effort that rational, open life permanently demands from us. The revolt against reason, in all its forms, is at bottom a revolt against that strain. The irrationalist tradition offers to carry it for you. The price, always, is your freedom.

⁹The neo-reactionary movement has coined a sticky name for it: "The Cathedral." Peter Thiel seem to have embraced this fringe movement bringing it into mainstream conversation in early 2025, in his Financial Times article "A time for truth and reconciliation" — though it is not clear what kind of "reconciliation" he has in mind, given that he cites the violent French Revolution as motivation. It is worth pausing on the structure of the argument, because it is an old one in new clothes: institutions are broken, consensus is manufactured, truth has been captured — and what is needed is a strong hand to cut through it all. The contradiction is hard to miss. No one can know the truth, the argument goes — and then, in the very next breath: but we do. It is, in the end, the same argument that Rousseau and Marx made — dressed differently, but identical in structure: someone, somewhere, has access to a truth that the corrupted institutions cannot see. That someone, conveniently, is always the person making the argument.

Conclusion: The Unglamorous Virtue

The rationalist tradition has never been exciting. Kant's *Sapere aude* is a call to intellectual bravery, but intellectual bravery is not the kind of thing that fills stadiums. Popper's piecemeal social engineering is admirably honest about the limits of political knowledge, but nobody marches in the streets for incremental reform. Russell's scientific temper is a beautiful and necessary thing, but it lacks the emotional intensity of a rally, a myth, a strong man's promise.

The irrationalist tradition offers something the rationalist tradition cannot match: the thrill of certainty, the warmth of tribal belonging, the excitement of a great historical drama in which you have been given a part. These are real human needs. The people who respond to them are not stupid or wicked — they are human, which means they are susceptible to exactly the things that centuries of irrationalist political thought have learned to exploit.

Resisting that offer requires understanding that the egalitarian commitment is not abstract. It is the foundation on which everything else is built — and, at its best, what the Western tradition has to offer: not as a claim of superiority, but as a contribution to a shared human project: the slow, painful, never-finished work of building a world in which every person counts, in which no one is merely a means to someone else's end, and in which the only honest way to live together when our interests conflict is to keep talking.

That this world of flesh and politics will never fully mirror the world of ideals is not a reason for despair — it is simply the human condition. The commitment does not ask us to achieve perfection. It asks us only to keep faith with the direction. And that, in the end, is what faith has always meant at its most basic: not the certainty that good will triumph, but the commitment to act as though it matters that it does. For anyone who takes the Christian ethical tradition seriously, that should not be a difficult ask.

The question is whether we have the will to use the intellectual tools we have inherited. Not the will of Carlyle's hero — the will to dominate, to override, to silence. The quieter, more demanding will that Kant was describing: the will to think, even when thinking is uncomfortable. To argue, even when argument is slow. To maintain institutions, even when they are frustrating. To extend the circle of moral consideration, even when the instinct is to draw it tighter.

The revolt against reason is permanent. It will outlast every particular political movement that has expressed it, because it is rooted in something real — in the genuine difficulty of rational life, and in the genuine appeal of the alternative. What is not permanent is the open society. It has to be chosen, again, by every generation that inherits it.

That defense begins, as Kant said, with a very simple act of courage: daring to think.



A Note on the Works Discussed

The central works in this argument are Karl Popper's *The Open Society and Its Enemies* (1945), Ernst Cassirer's *The Myth of the State* (1946), Immanuel Kant's *What Is Enlightenment?* (1784), and Bertrand Russell's essay *The Revolt Against Reason* (1935). The main elements of what this essay has called the "irrationalist" tradition are best encountered in Niccolò Machiavelli's *The Prince* (1513), Thomas Carlyle's *On Heroes, Hero-Worship, and the Heroic in History* (1841), Friedrich Nietzsche's *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887). All of them repay direct reading — including, perhaps especially, the ones whose conclusions we should resist.

Voices

"Rationality, in the sense of an appeal to a universal and impersonal standard of truth, is of supreme importance, not only in ages in which it easily prevails, but also, and even more, in those less fortunate times in which it is despised and rejected as the vain dream of men who lack the virility to kill where they cannot agree."

— Bertrand Russell

"There is no history of mankind, there is only an indefinite number of histories of all kinds of aspects of human life. And one of these is the history of political power. This is elevated into the 'history of the world'. But this, I hold, is an offense against every decent conception of mankind. It is hardly better than to treat the history of embezzlement or of robbery or of poisoning as the history of mankind. For the history of power politics is nothing but the history of international crime and mass murder. This history is taught in schools, and some of the greatest criminals are extolled as its heroes."

— Karl Popper

"I do not wish to hide the fact that I can only look with repugnance upon the puffed-up pretentiousness of all these volumes filled with wisdom,

such as are fashionable nowadays. For I am fully satisfied that the accepted methods must endlessly increase these follies and blunders, and that even the complete annihilation of all these fanciful achievements could not possibly be as harmful as this fictitious science with its accursed fertility."

— Immanuel Kant

"The choice before us is not simply an intellectual affair, or a matter of taste. It is a moral decision. For the question whether we adopt some more or less radical form of irrationalism, or whether we adopt that minimum concession to irrationalism which I have termed 'critical rationalism', will deeply affect our whole attitude towards other men, and towards the problems of social life."

— Karl Popper